

YEASHU YUVRAJ

Over the past three decades, almost every major Indian rock act has been discovered playing at Independence Rock. "With its association with Farhad Wadia and Independence Rock, Mahindra Group has strengthened the cross-cultural phenomenon that has taken over the world," says Jay Shah, vice president-cultural outreach, Mahindra Group.

In the past, the 'Woodstock of India' has been the breaking ground for several bands and pop acts, such as Mirage, Orphean Revival, Indus Creed, Chakravyuh, Brahma, Zero, Pentagram, Shweta Shetty, Shiamak Davar, Ezee Meat, Short Circuit, Voices, Shiva, Jasmine Bharucha, Suneeta Rao, Pythogoras and the Right Angles, Gary Lawyer, Parikrama, Zero, Agni, and Millennium. "With three decades under its belt, Mahindra Independence Rock has become the cornerstone of the genre in India, and this edition stands out as it encapsulates the evolution of rock over the years," concludes V.G. Jairam, founder, Hyperlink Brand Solutions. ■

–Neha Kirpal

CINEMA

There's No Planet B

All Living Things–Environmental Film Festival (ALT EFF) returns with 72 films to be screened across multiple locations from Nov. 22 to Dec. 8

India's largest environmental cinema-based festival, All Living Things–Environmental Film Festival (ALT EFF), is back with its fifth edition and a catalogue of 72 films in different categories. The 100-plus screenings will be held across over 65 locations in India from November 22 to December 8.

For Kunal Khanna, co-founder and festival director, ALT EFF's core mission has been to use film as a medium to create awareness and drive action. "Film is such a powerful medium to create widespread awareness. You can do it quite rapidly and you can do it at scale; especially in the current digital world," he says. Although the on-ground festival will be held in Tier-1 cities as well as in most Tier-2 and Tier-3 cities, there is also a pay-as-you-feel model for online viewing. ALT EFF has even expanded its international footprint with screenings set to take place in Costa Rica, Nepal, the US and Australia, among others.

Primarily a film festival, the platform is also bringing in different mediums to create a more powerful impact with its content. Apart from the new category 'Environmental Journalism' to highlight and encourage films in this genre, the organisers are launching ALT EFF Voices, a spoken word platform. "The participants may or may not be filmmakers, but have their own experience of the changing environment and the struggles that they have faced," says Khanna.

Mumbai-based artist and researcher Natasha Sharma, whose directorial short film *Gutter Ki Machhli* is being screened at the festival, has weaved together the voices of the children, youth and women of a rehabilitation and resettlement colony in Govandi, Mumbai, through their drawings and poetry to "vocalise, localise and visualise" their experiences of climate change in their poorly built homes and neighbourhood. "I have been working with the youth and the children of Govandi for the last six years to reclaim their public spaces through art-based methods, because public spaces are an indicator of the well-being of that place," she says. The animation film is a result of the workshops she took with them to understand how they perceive climate and environmental change. She believes that platforms such as ALT EFF are a powerful tool to take these voices to different parts of the country with their decentralised approach.

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Writer and director Arun Fulara seconds her opinion. "Going forward, we will have more such platforms, given that the younger generations are more aware and concerned about what's happening," he says. His film *Shera* depicts the friendship between two boys growing up in Kumaon and how migration threatens to put an end to it. An elusive leopard and its peaceful coexistence with the community forms a significant thread in the film. "The challenge is to tell engaging stories which are able to explore people in perspectives that they've not been in. You can't frighten people into action," he signs off. ■

–Deepali Dhingra





A still from *Gutter Ki Machhli*, (right) *Shera*